

But having kids doesn't have to equal going broke, if you make some adjustments. Your lifestyle is going to change drastically. I'm not just talking about your sleep patterns, but eating out, movies, clothing—the things you absentmindedly spent money on. Those days are over. Every dime will begin to matter. You have to have open discussions about maternity leave, who's going to work, who's going to stay home with the baby. You have to find out what you are eligible for in terms of Child Tax Credits and bonuses. Most good day cares cost about \$1,000 a month. How are you going to pay for this? Are you eligible for subsidized day care? Also, life insurance and wills—you'll need both now. When it was just the two of you, you could live on the edge a little. But a baby means you have to become much more careful, and you need a clear financial plan in case anything happens to you or your partner.

Then there are the college funds, catastrophe cash, and other investments to consider. It's not just theory anymore. You *need* to set aside money when you have children. It's never been more important to save and invest for the future. So figure out which things you won't miss—the trips, the \$25 yoga classes, dinner out three times a week—and funnel that money into your new funds. And by all means, please rethink your plan to buy a house. Consider that you might be better off renting until you're sure you're finished growing your family, even if quarters are cramped for a couple of years. Incurring more debt when you have a baby is a recipe for financial disaster down the road.

Like I said, my kids are the best things that ever happened to me and my wife, but if you're at all ambivalent about the idea of parenting, and especially if money is a real concern, consider not having kids at all. It might be controversial to say this, but no kids means more money to save, invest, and retire on. Being childless means living a different life, for certain, but it can be equally rewarding, especially if you have the money to enjoy it.